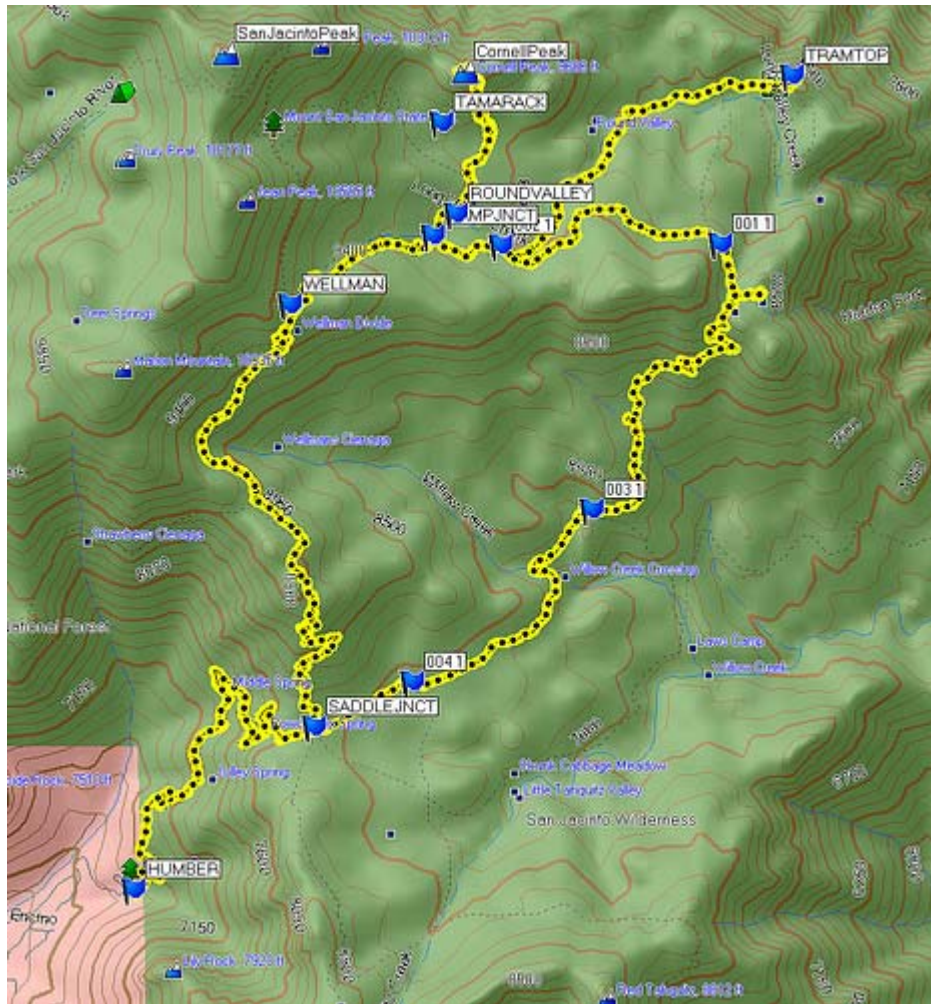
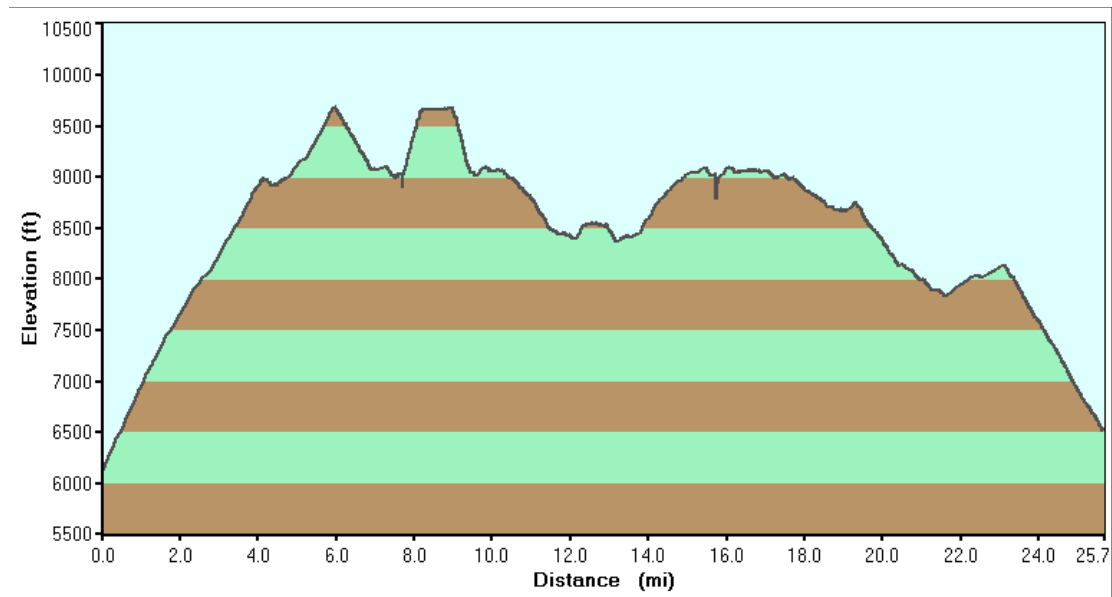


WTC Cornell Peak Experience Backpack

Humber Park to Tamarack

3 days, 2 nights, 25.5 miles, 5600 ft of gain





*Day 1- Humber Park to Tamarack Campground Via Wellman Divide
7.5 miles, 3200 ft of gain*

*Day 2 – Cornell Peak and Long Valley
7.1 miles, 1100 ft of gain*

*Day 3 – Tamarack Campground to Humber via Hidden Lake Divide
9.8 miles, 600 ft of gain (and a whole heck of a lot of downhill)*

Bill Payne was nice enough to plan a private WTC experience backpack up to the San Jacinto area that would involve camping at the Tamarack Campground and bagging Cornell Peak after a cross country hike. The plan was to hike in from Humber Park via Devil's Slide and take the western trails over Wellman Deliver to Tamarack Valley campground, camp there, do Cornell Peak as a day hike the next day, and then come out Sunday via a slightly longer eastern route.

Kim and I were both eager to go having never camped in the area but we were both short vacation days after the various events of the past few months. As a result with Bill's consent I applied for a separate 3 person permit with the intention of hiking up Friday night.



For a while it appeared Kim and I might be going in alone (Kim suggested I stop referring to the hike as ‘death march through darkness’) but then Andrew stepped forward to join us. So, 6:30 pm Friday evening found us at the trailhead in Humber Park sweating, shouldering our packs, and heading up the mountain.



The Devil's Slide trail is 2.5 miles with a gradual climb of about 1700 ft until you reach Saddle Junction at which point we would climb some more to reach Wellman Divide and then drop into Round Valley.

Kim and I had both done the Turtle Rock conditioning hike the night before so both of us were a bit tired to begin with which made for a slow start.

There were a fair number of people on the trail though most were on their way down. Out of the few we met going up most seemed to be heading for the Saddle Junction area to spend the night. None that I talked to were going as far as Tamarack.

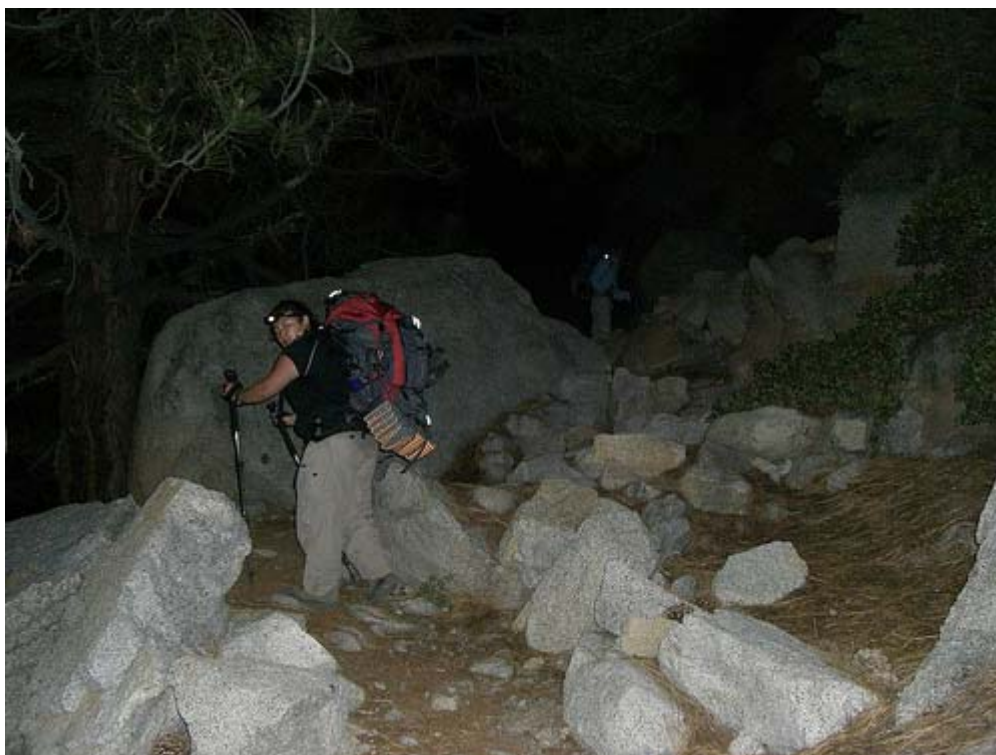


This guy was walking down the trail strumming his instrument which he told us was a backpacking guitar.



The sun was going down quickly which offered some relief from the heat and we were also treated to some excellent sunset views.

It was dusk by the time we passed Saddle Junction and not long after that we were forced to turn on our headlamps. The moon came up a few hours later but by that time was of little use due to the tree cover along the trail.



The weather was just about as perfect as we could have asked for. I was wearing a short sleeve shirt and shorts and the only time I became chilly was when we stopped for any amount of time. A slight breeze was enough to cool us off but didn't require additional clothing.



The climb up Wellman Divide was the most costly climb time wise. By then it was around 10 pm and the moon had come up. As we went up the switchbacks we could see the lights of Palm Springs far below and off in the distance the water of the Salton Sea reflecting the red-range moon. Sadly the conditions were a bit beyond my simple point and shoot camera.



We reached the turn to Round Valley around 11:30 pm.

As we were making our way on the trail the campground I thought I saw a reflector up ahead. After a moment a second “reflector” appeared next to it and they both promptly started to move. We soon became aware of a number of deer (at least that’s what we assume it was) all around us. Turning our headlamps to spotlight mode we could look in almost any direction and see eyes reflecting back at us.

We passed a sign reading Tamarack but I thought we’d have a bit further to the campground proper. Right about then we came around a turn in the trail I caught sight of a trash bag hanging from a tree branch and Bill’s voice came from a nearby tent. We’d managed to stumble directly into their campsite.

It was a little after midnight and we were quick to set up our tents and get to bed. While Kim and I had a regular backpacking tent Andrew went the tarp route.



We slept well that night and awoke the next morning to say hello to the rest of the group. The group that hiked in Friday morning ended up with 4 people: Bill, Katie, Sean, and Helene.



After breakfast we lightened our packs somewhat and after a quick consultation with the maps took off for the nearby Cornell Peak.

Cornell was visible from our campsite and the route was actually up the hillside behind us.



The route was a mix of picking our way through underbrush and the occasional rock scramble but everyone powered up it without difficulty. There were faint use trails here and there but mostly we were just picking our way up as best we could while remaining on the east side of the peak.





The top of the accessible portion of the climb ended at the 10 ft crack described in the HPS peak guide and pictured above. There are handholds but the moment your at the top you look down over a 15+ foot drop on the other side. From there the actual highest point on the summit block requires edging along a rock with exposure over a drop of several hundred feet.

The short fall:



The long fall: (Hopefully you left your car keys with the other members of your group.)



Helene and I both climbed up the crack and I was extremely close to trying the last bit but was persuaded to not too. Instead we climbed down to the others.



We looked around for the peak log without luck so after a few more pictures we headed down.



Cornell from across Round Valley meadow.

Being another warm day as we headed back to camp someone had the brilliant observation that the Palm Springs Tramway over in Long Valley would make a decent day hike and had the added benefit of cold beer. It didn't take much to convince the group and we were off.



Burgers and beer were enjoyed by all. For some reason though no one was in a hurry to sit next to us.



Now somewhat sated we shouldered our packs and headed back to camp where we enjoyed a relaxing time laying out for a bit before dinner and happy hour.



We then found out why Bill's pack was so heavy. It wasn't so much the 2 liters of wine as it was the 10 pounds of assorted food that had somehow made it into his pack. They were both eager to hand out extra food.

We also had a show and tell going over various pieces of gear ranging from lightweight alternatives to survival tips.

By the time the sun was heading down the wind had picked up enough we were putting on our warm clothes and heading for our tents.



Strangely a few hours after the sun went down the wind was still going but the air temperature went up easily 10 degrees. It became almost uncomfortably warm in our tents (even for Kim.) I don't think anyone slept as well that second day.



Our route out was 8.8 miles according to the map and we had some sights to see along the way. We broke camp about 8:30 am after pumping some water and we were off.

A few miles south of Long Valley Bill took us down the turnoff to Hidden Lake. It appears on some of our maps but not others and besides two women who were leaving as we came in we had the area to ourselves.



There was also a spectacular lookout spot



And Matt found a nice rock to stand right on the edge of.



The lake didn't have any fresh water feeding it but was alive with tadpoles, bugs, and various other small critters.





The day was getting warm but we now had our motivation for getting down the mountain: a margaritas and Mexican food!

Of course we did have almost 10 miles to cover so there were breaks here and there.



The longest part of the hike out was the 2.5 mile tromp down Devil's Slide trail at the very end. It was hot enough we didn't see many people on the way down though we did run into some forest service employees and had our permits checked.



And finally the way all trips should end, margaritas!

